

buried deep within the OS that would perhaps have come to the forefront if it weren't for the endless controversies about its UI and the Store.

Windows 8 touches every part of Windows, removing unused features going way back and touching up even the remotest areas of the Windows experience.

Let's start with the boot process, which now supports – and for Windows hardware manufacturers even mandates – secure boot. Secure boot ensures that only code signed by Microsoft can run on boot, which almost nullifies the risk of boot viruses.

Windows Explorer as you might know now has a ribbon-based UI, which actually manages to save space since it is condensed most of the time. The file copy dialog has been heavily enhanced with support for pausing transfers, combining multiple transfers into one window, and viewing a graph of the performance rather than just a snapshot and changing estimate of time remaining. Also, Windows finally supports mounting ISO files and throws in VHD and IMG mounting support for good measure.

The task manager too has received a lot of love and is now a much more powerful, yet simpler and prettier tool for understanding what is going on in your system.

There are even bigger changes, for example Windows 8 now has much better multi-monitor support. Each screen can now have its own taskbar that can show all applications, or the applications open on that screen. Each monitor can now be given a separate wallpaper as well.

Another major feature is the new Storage Spaces system for managing hard drives. Storage Spaces takes away the pain of managing physical hard drives, and rather focuses on virtual storage spaces. The way this works is that you can use a number of hard drives to create a storage pool. This storage pool can then have a number of storage spaces, each of which appears like your traditional hard drive partition.

What is great about this feature is that it supports redundant storage and storage virtualization. Redundant storage means that each piece of data you store is stored on at least two hard drives. Even if one fails, your data will continue to be accessible. Storage virtualization on the other hand means that you can essentially create a 10TB storage space even if you are only using three 1TB drives. The storage is virtualized so it will not be allocated till it is actually used. This way you can create a 10TB partition now, and only buy hard drives when the space in existing drives actually begins to fill up. Since Windows maintains two copies of each piece of data,